Pavel Golikov

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PROFESSIONAL PROFILE

AI Researcher specializing in machine reasoning and alignment. Blends formal logic with rigorous low-level systems engineering to architect custom agentic frameworks and highly creative adversarial evaluations. Former Military Intelligence Operator with a Top Secret clearance, bringing a rigorous, threat-modeling mindset to AI security and model capability evaluations.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Languages: Python, C++, Java, SQL, LaTeX
ML & AI: PyTorch, vLLM, HuggingFace, Transformers, Google/Anthropic/OpenAI APIs, Agent Harness
Systems & Infrastructure: Linux/Ubuntu Server, AWS, Apache Flink, Distributed GPU Clusters
Core Competencies: Large Language Models (LLMs), Machine Reasoning, AI Alignment, Context Management, Mechanistic Interpretability, Adversarial Evaluations, Threat Modeling, Distributed Systems

FIRST-AUTHOR AI RESEARCH

- **ArbiGraph** | *GitHub* 2026 – Present
  - Built **ArbiGraph**, a Python evaluation framework for testing whether LLM agents can follow long, multi-step workflows without losing, mixing up, or reusing stale intermediate state.
  - Converted math, word-problem, and Python-tracing tasks into automatically generated workflows with executable ground truth, enabling exact grading without manual labels.
  - Added controls for workflow length, branching, irrelevant distractors, and value types, letting researchers reproduce agent failure modes and scale difficulty without hand-crafting prompts.
  - Implemented the agent evaluation harness around a calculator tool, including answer extraction, tool-call validation, continuation handling, and repair prompts for incomplete or malformed runs.
- **Robust Reasoning Benchmark (RRB)** | *arXiv* | *DOI* | *GitHub* 2026
  - Designed a highly creative adversarial evaluation framework leveraging 13 deterministic textual perturbations to decouple an LLM's mechanical deciphering from its underlying mathematical logic.
  - Demonstrated that the attention drift occurs *within a single query's Chain-of-Thought*, empirically showing that intermediate reasoning steps pollute the dense attention mechanism, identifying the optimal **granularity of reasoning** as a critical open research problem.
  - Engineered custom mechanistic interpretability pipelines in **PyTorch** to extract and analyze causal attention probability matrices across token index boundaries, testing models ranging from 7B to 30B parameters.
- **Fusing Adds and Shifts for Efficient Dot Products** | *IEEE CAL* | GitHub 2026
  Hardware ML Research *Toronto, ON*
  - Proposed and validated a novel algorithmic optimization for dot-product computations, demonstrating a strong foundational understanding of hardware-level ML primitives and efficiency.

ENGINEERING & PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

- **Systems & Infrastructure Engineering (MSc Thesis)** 2020 – 2022
  University of Toronto *Toronto, ON*
  - Engineered a flexible IoT distributed data-streaming framework from scratch, designed to automatically partition computational streaming queries between edge devices and cloud instances.
  - Built the full software stack: programmed Arduino/C++ sensors for real-time biological data collection (EMG/ECG), developed custom socket networking protocols, and deployed cloud infrastructure using **AWS** and **Apache Flink**.
- **Intelligence Operator** 2013 – 2018
  Canadian Armed Forces *Canada*
  - Held a **Top Secret** security clearance, conducting rigorous analysis of classified information streams to produce actionable intelligence reports for command elements.
  - Developed a strong adversarial threat-modeling mindset, emphasizing operational security, rigorous data validation, and the identification of logical vulnerabilities in complex, multi-agent scenarios.
- **Mathematics Teacher** 2012 – 2013 & 2018 – 2019
  Blyth Academy *Toronto*
  - Taught foundational mathematics to students in Grades 10, 11, and 12, developing the ability to distill and communicate complex quantitative concepts.

EDUCATION

- **University of Toronto** Toronto, ON
  PhD in Computer Science (Paused to transition to industry) *2022 – Present*
- **University of Toronto** Toronto, ON
  Master of Science (MSc) in Computer Science *2020 – 2022*
- **University of Toronto** Toronto, ON
  Bachelor of Science (BSc) in Mathematics and Philosophy (Formal Logic) *Graduated 2011*